

● CANVAS · 1-PAGE GTM + 90-DAY PLAN + WORKED EXAMPLE

The AI Startup *GTM* Canvas

One page that forces the ten go-to-market decisions most AI teams leave implicit, a 90-day worksheet that turns them into a plan, and an illustrative filled example so you can see the level of specificity that makes a canvas useful.

HOW TO FILL IT IN

1. Fill the canvas in pencil, in one 90-minute session with the founders. Leave a box blank rather than writing something vague.
2. Every box should contain something a skeptical investor could check: a named segment, a price, a number, a competitor.
3. Write the riskiest assumption in Risks, then design the first 30 days of the plan to test it.
4. Revisit monthly. A canvas that never changes is a canvas nobody reads.

BEST FOR

AI and AI-infrastructure founders, pre-seed to Series A

TIME

90 minutes for the canvas, 60 minutes for the 90-day plan

INTERACTIVE VERSION

shilikajain.com/tools/gtm-planner

CANVAS

Go-to-market on one page

Company: _____ Version / date: _____ Owner: _____

1 · MARKET**WHERE**

Which segment first, and why now? What changed (model capability, cost, regulation, platform shift) that makes this possible this year?

2 · ICP**WHO**

Company type and size, trigger event, buyer title, user title. Who signs, who uses, who can block?

3 · PROBLEM

The painful job in the buyer's words. What does it cost them today, in hours, money or risk?

4 · ALTERNATIVES

What they use now: incumbent, in-house build, general-purpose LLM, agency, nothing.

5 · POSITIONING

For [ICP] who [trigger/problem], [product] is a [category] that [key value]. Unlike [alternative], we [unique capability + proof].

6 · PRICING

Model (seat, usage, outcome, platform fee), entry price, expansion path. Does gross margin survive inference costs at scale?

7 · MOTION

Product-led, sales-led, partner-led or community-led? Sales cycle length? Who closes the first 10 deals?

8 · CHANNELS**MAX 3**

The three channels you will test first, each with a budget and an owner. Why will your ICP see you there?

9 · METRICS

One north-star metric, plus leading indicators: activation rate, qualified pipeline, CAC, payback, net revenue retention.

10 · RISKS**TEST FIRST**

Riskiest assumptions: model commoditisation, data access, trust and security review, platform dependency, a big player shipping the same feature.

PLAN 90-day worksheet

Each month has one job. Month 1 tests the riskiest assumption, month 2 doubles down on whatever produced signal, month 3 makes it repeatable.

	DAYS 1 TO 30 · TEST	DAYS 31 TO 60 · FOCUS	DAYS 61 TO 90 · REPEAT
Goal One sentence, one number			
Assumption tested From box 10			
Channels Max 3			
Key actions 3 to 5 per month			
Assets needed Pages, decks, demos, data			
Budget			
Owner			
Success metric And the kill threshold			
What we learned Fill in at month end			

Weekly 30-minute review. Three questions only: what did the numbers do, what did we learn from customers, what do we stop doing? Write the answers under the month column.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL COMPANY

Worked example: "Ledgerlight"

A made-up AI startup used only to show the level of detail. Not a real company, client or result.

1 · MARKET

Mid-market finance teams in the US and UK. LLMs can now read messy invoices and contracts reliably enough for a human-in-the-loop review flow; this was not practical two years ago.

2 · ICP

B2B SaaS companies with 200 to 1,000 staff, 3 to 10 people in finance, just switched ERP or failed an audit. Buyer: VP Finance. User: AP lead. Blocker: IT security.

3 · PROBLEM

"We spend the first week of every month chasing invoice mismatches." Month-end close slips by days; errors surface in the audit.

4 · ALTERNATIVES

Manual review in spreadsheets, the AP module of their ERP, an outsourced bookkeeping firm.

5 · POSITIONING

For finance teams who close the month late because of invoice mismatches, Ledgerlight is an AI accounts-payable reviewer that flags errors before they post. Unlike ERP rules, it reads the contract, not just the PO.

6 · PRICING

Platform fee plus per-invoice usage. Annual contract, entry tier for under 2,000 invoices a month. Margin checked at 3x current volume.

7 · MOTION

Sales-led with a free 14-day pilot on last month's invoices. Founder closes first 10 deals. Target cycle: 30 to 45 days.

8 · CHANNELS

1. Founder LinkedIn to VP Finance audience. 2. ERP marketplace listing plus integration. 3. Earned media and podcasts in finance-ops trade press.

9 · METRICS

North star: invoices reviewed per week. Leading: pilots started, pilot-to-paid rate, security review pass rate, CAC payback under 12 months.

10 · RISKS

IT security blocks pilots. ERP vendor ships a similar feature. Test first: can we pass a security questionnaire in under a week? (Prepare a trust page and SOC 2 roadmap.)

90-day plan, condensed

MONTH	GOAL	KEY ACTIONS	KILL THRESHOLD
1 · Test	5 pilots started	Trust page live; 40 founder-led conversations; 3 posts a week; ERP listing submitted	Fewer than 2 pilots, or security blocks 3 in a row
2 · Focus	2 paid conversions	Pilot playbook; first customer story; podcast pitches to finance-ops shows	Pilot-to-paid below 1 in 4
3 · Repeat	10 pilots in pipeline	Data report on invoice error patterns (anonymised); trade press pitch; webinar with ERP partner	Report earns no coverage or inbound

● NEXT STEP

Want a senior operator *on your launch?*

Templates get you organised. Coverage, citations and pipeline come from judgement: which angle a journalist will actually take, which channel deserves the next dollar, and what to cut.

Book a 30-minute teardown. Bring your launch plan, your positioning or your last campaign and leave with a prioritised list of fixes.

Book a 30-minute teardown: shilikajain.com/contact

Six years

PR and go-to-market for Web3, AI and cybersecurity founders.

50+ protocols

Launches, funding rounds and token events supported.

Tier-1 outlets

Forbes, CoinDesk, Cointelegraph, Decrypt, The Block, Blockworks, AI Magazine.

Prefer to self-serve first? Try the free interactive planners, budget calculator and checklist at shilikajain.com/tools. More downloads live at shilikajain.com/resources.

Engagements: fractional PR retainer \$5K to \$12K per month. Launch sprint \$15K to \$40K.